

Anatomy of a Great Essay

A Visual Guide to Expert Writing

LEVEL 1 – THE WHOLE ESSAY

A GOOD TITLE

Be clear, not clever. Avoid cryptic titles and inside jokes. Use one of these curiosity triggers:

1. Pose a question or puzzle
2. Open a sequence of events with an unknown resolution
3. Violate their expectations
4. Signal that others know what they don't

MAKE READERS CARE

A good introduction fails to repel. Kill these Introduction patterns:

- Background → Thesis
- General → Specific
- Gap → Niche

The text is a solution; the introduction says, *Here's the problem.*

THE PROBLEM, SOLVED

Return to the opening problem, showing that it is settled and linking its resolution to a broader question.

FROM STABILITY TO INSTABILITY

Readers trade their attention for value, and value is the solution to a problem. But a stable reader has no problem to solve. So the goal of the Introduction is to move readers from stability to instability.

COMMON GROUND

To motivate readers to take your problem seriously, open with the general context of the problem that most readers take for granted.

PROBLEM

Taken together, these elements will help persuade readers that your essay will address a problem worth solving.

SOLUTION

The Solution offers a way out of the cost imposed by the Problem. Its value is borrowed—your essay is worth exactly as much as the Problem it relieves. Here is the promise of a resolution, which will be fulfilled in the body of the essay.

SET READER EXPECTATIONS

Every unit of discourse opens with an Index, 1–3 sentences that readers use to decide what the unit is doing.

KEEP THE PROMISE

Everything after the Index develops the idea it introduced, threading its Key Terms through every sentence.

HOOKS DON'T WORK

Readers don't value catchy openings; they value the solution to a relevant problem. But a catchy opening—a startling fact, a quote, or a story—works when it vividly sets up that problem.

INVERT YOUR POINT

Value is a change in the reader's head, so your Point is only worth something relative to what it displaces. The Status Quo is what it displaces: the idea your Point exists to overturn. Find it by inverting your Point and stating it in your reader's words, sincerely enough that they nod in agreement.

BE FAIR

Don't dismiss the Status Quo out of hand; grant it what's right, helpful, productive, or at least understandable. Conceding first earns you the trust to upset it next.

BUT...

Upset the Status Quo: show what's wrong, incomplete, outdated, or inappropriate about the idea your reader currently believes. Signal this move with *But* or *However*.

STATE THE COST

Instability alone isn't a problem; the reader must also perceive the cost of leaving the instability unresolved, or the benefit of resolving it. This is why it's crucial to write with *specific readers* in mind: to establish the value of your Point, you must know what your reader cares about.

MAKE YOUR POINT

The Point is your essay's central claim—what you want readers to walk away believing. State it after showing that what they believed is wrong, and that being wrong costs them. Its value is the distance it moves them from where they began.

LEVEL 2 – THE INTRODUCTION

COMMON GROUND

STABILITY

PRELUDE

STATUS QUO

CONCESSION

PROBLEM

DESTABILIZING CONDITION

CONSEQUENCE

INSTABILITY

SOLUTION

POINT

Anatomy of a Great Essay

LEVEL 3 — INDEX & DISCUSSION

SIZE VARIES

The Index may vary in size — from a single line to a few paragraphs long — depending on the problem you're setting up for this unit of discourse.

KEY TERMS

The Index often closes with Key Terms — the words naming the unit's core concepts. Readers expect them developed throughout the Discussion.

FIXED STRUCTURE

The Index–Discussion structure is fixed, like Subject–Verb–Object. Readers perceive it intuitively. They use the Index to interpret the Discussion, whether you intend it or not.

INDEX

DISCUSSION

1–3 SENTENCES

The Index within one paragraph can be a single sentence. Use 2–3 when you're:

- Writing about something complex
- Opening with an opposition (*X. However, Y...*)
- Posing a question (*X. Why X? As we will see, Y...*)

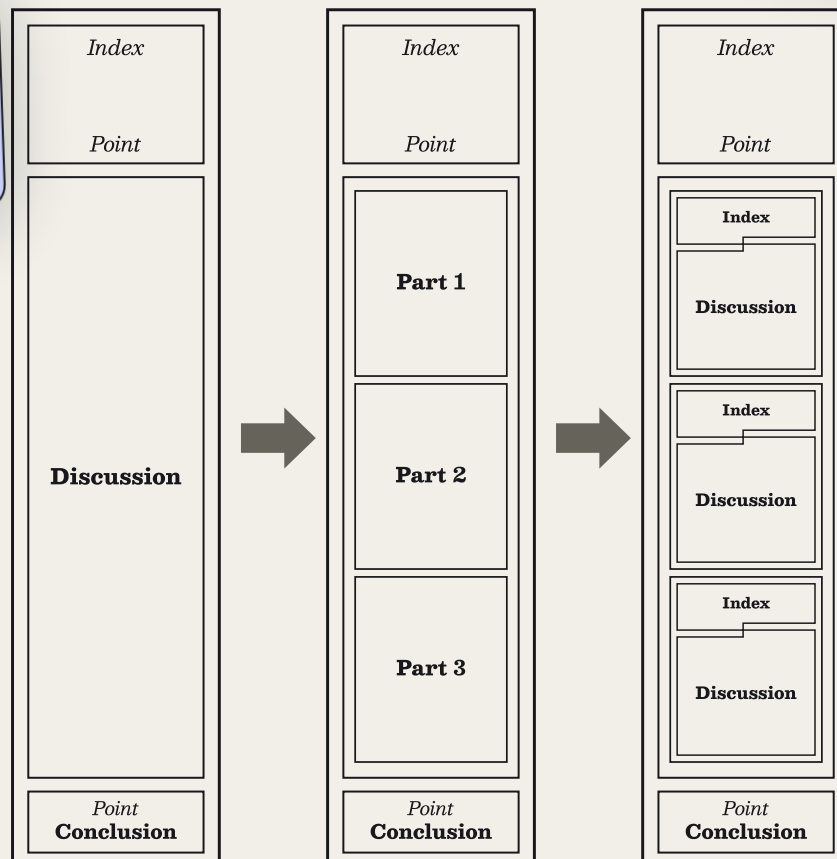
THE SKIM TEST

Read only the Index position of each paragraph. If that skeleton outlines the whole story, your structure works.

LEVEL 4 — WRITING IN FRACTALS

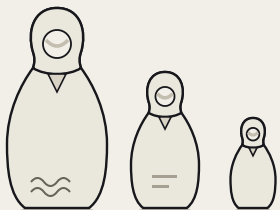
THE WHOLE AND ITS PARTS

All whole structures have parts. All parts mirror the structure of the whole.



EVERY PART REPEATS THE ANATOMY

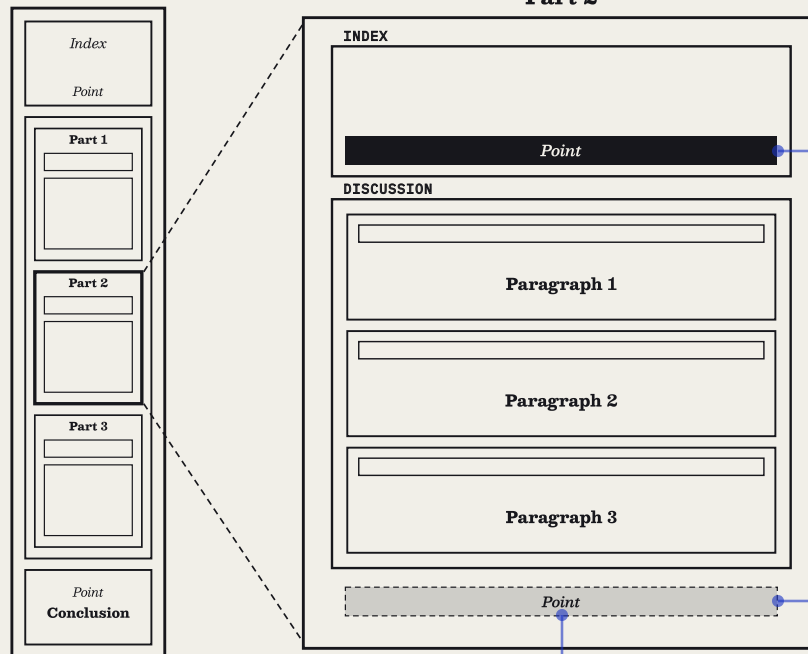
A section is a small essay. Its Index states the section's Point, and that Point does two jobs at once—controls the paragraphs in its own Discussion, and supports the essay's Point above it.



Anatomy of a Great Essay

LEVEL 5 — INSIDE A SECTION

Part 2



POINT FIRST

Your writing seems clearest when Points come early in the Index structure, at the end of the beginning.

POINT LAST

If you don't want to state the point up front, use the Index to set it up. In Point-Last structure, put the point at the *end* of the Discussion, not in the middle where readers will miss it.

THE ACCIDENTAL POINT-LAST

The biggest structural problem is Point-Last structure—not by design, but by accident. The Index fails to give readers the themes they need, and readers can't find the Point.

POINT ONCE, NOT TWICE

Make a unit's Point at either the beginning or the end, but not both. (That's why the bottom bar is ghosted.)

LEVEL 6 — KEY TERMS

KEY TERMS

The Index sets reader expectations by announcing Key Terms. Those Key Terms are threaded through every sentence in the Discussion. Readers experience that thread as *coherence*.

Other people besides the **Arabs** have used **fire** as a means of **stopping rain**.

INDEX

The **Sulka** of New Britain heat stones **red hot** in the **fire** and put them out in the rain. They think the rain will soon **cease to fall**, for it does not like to be **burned**. The **Telugas** send a little girl out into the rain with a **burning** piece of wood to show to the rain. At Port Stevens, the **medicine-men** **drive away rain** by throwing **fire-sticks** into the air. Any man of the **Anula** tribe can **stop rain** by **warming** a green stick in the **fire** and striking it against the wind.¹

DISCUSSION

To **unaided human eyes**, the universe **beyond** our **solar system** **looks like** a few thousand **glowing** dots in the **night sky**, plus the faint, hazy **streaks** of the **Milky Way**. But if you **ask** an **astronomer** what is **out there** in **reality**, you will be **told** not about dots or **streaks**, but about **stars**: spheres of incandescent **gas** **millions of kilometres** in diameter and **light years** away from us.

INDEX

You will be **told** that the **sun** is a typical **star**, and looks different from the others only because we are much **closer** to it – though still some **150 million kilometres** away. Yet, even at those **unimaginable distances**, we are **confident** that we **know** what makes **stars** shine: you will be **told** that they are powered by the nuclear energy released by transmutation – the conversion of one chemical element into another (mainly hydrogen into helium).²

DISCUSSION

PEOPLE

the Arabs
↓
the Sulka
↓
the Telugas
↓
medicine-men
↓
the Anula

FIRE

fire
↓
red hot
↓
burned
↓
burning wood
↓
fire-sticks
↓
warming

STOPPING RAIN

stopping rain
↓
cease to fall
↓
drive away rain
↓
stop rain

THEMATIC STRINGS

Repetition, synonyms, and pronouns link words together in *thematic strings*.

UNIVERSE

solar system
↓
night sky
↓
Milky Way
↓
astronomer
↓
stars
↓
gas
↓
sun
↓
star

SCALE

beyond
↓
out there
↓
millions of kilometres
↓
light years away
↓
closer
↓
unimaginable distances

EPISTEMOLOGY

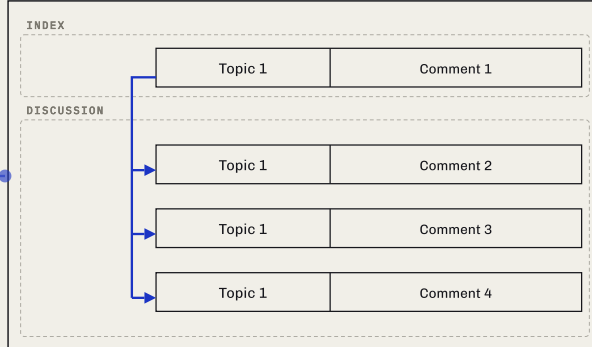
unaided human eyes
↓
looks like
↓
ask
↓
reality
↓
told
↓
confident
↓
know
↓
glowing
↓
streaks

Anatomy of a Great Essay

LEVEL 7 – PARAGRAPH PATTERNS

CONSTANT THEME

The same element is repeated as the Topic in successive clauses. Each clause then adds new information in the Comment, keeping the focus anchored on one main Key Term while elaborating different aspects of it.



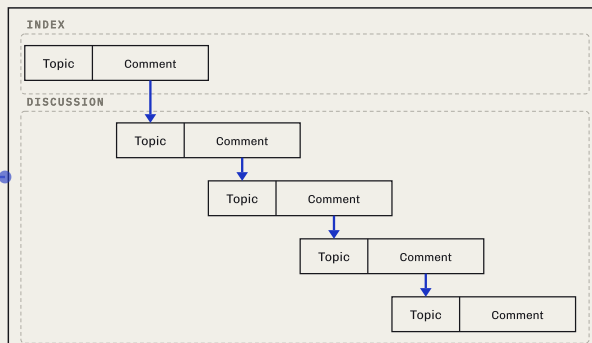
Happiness is not something that happens. **It** is not the result of good fortune or random chance. **It** is not something that money can buy or power command. **It** does not depend on outside events, but, rather, on how we interpret them. **Happiness**, in fact, is a condition that must be prepared for, cultivated, and defended privately by each person.³

TOPIC & COMMENT

At the level of organization, every clause is made up of a Topic and a Comment. The Topic is the first meaningful element of a clause; it's the thing that the sentence tells a story about. Use the Topic to link clauses together in these paragraph patterns.

LINKING PATTERN

Old → New
Information Flow: the Comment of *Clause 1* introduces new information, which gets picked up in the Topic of *Clause 2*, where it functions as old, backwards-linking information. Likewise, the Comment of *Clause 2* introduces new information, which links forward to the Comment of *Clause 3*...



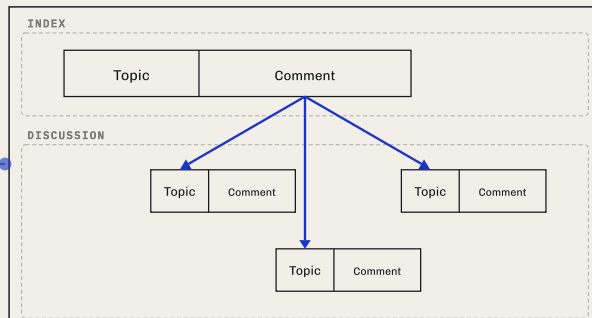
Outside his window Lorenz could watch **real weather**, **the early-morning fog** creeping along the Massachusetts Institute of Technology campus or **the low clouds** slipping over the rooftops from the Atlantic. **Fog** and **clouds** never arose in the model running on **his computer**. **The machine**, a **Royal McBee**, was a thicket of wiring and vacuum tubes that occupied an ungainly portion of Lorenz's office.⁴

ANOTHER FRACTAL

The Topic-Comment structure at the level of the clause is a scaled down version of the Index-Discussion structure at the level of the paragraph. Readers look to the Topic position to find out what this unit is about, like the Index; and the Comment position is where that idea is developed, like the Discussion.

SUPER THEME

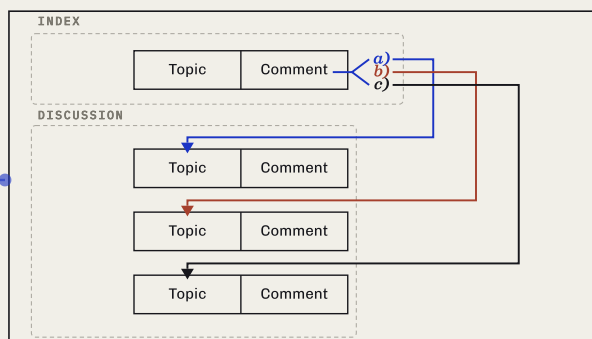
In the Index, the Comment introduces a category (aka hyponym). In the Discussion, the Topics don't repeat that category; instead, they name its parts (aka hypernyms).



When neuroscientists look directly at the **brain**, using a variety of techniques, they can actually see language in action in the left hemisphere. **The anatomy of the normal brain**—its bulges and creases—is slightly asymmetrical. **In some of the regions associated with language**, the differences are large enough to be seen with the naked eye. **Aphasics' brains** almost always show lesions in the left hemisphere.⁵

THEME PREVIEW

In the Index, the Comment previews the Key Terms. In the Discussion, those Key Terms are picked up in the Topics and developed in the Comments and through successive clauses.



In their theory of morality, Shweder et al. found three major clusters of moral themes, which they called the ethics of **autonomy**, **community**, and **divinity**. The ethic of **autonomy** is based on the idea that people are, first and foremost, autonomous individuals with wants, needs, and preferences. The ethic of **community** is based on the idea that people are, first and foremost, members of larger entities such as families, teams, armies, companies, tribes, and nations. The ethic of **divinity** is based on the idea that people are, first and foremost, temporary vessels within which a divine soul has been implanted.⁶

¹ James Frazer, *The Golden Bough*.

² David Deutsch, *The Beginning of Infinity*.

³ Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi, *Flow: The Psychology of Optimal Experience*.

⁴ James Gleick, *Chaos: Making a New Science*.

⁵ Steven Pinker, *The Language Instinct*.

⁶ Jonathan Haidt, *The Righteous Mind: Why Good People are Divided by Politics and Religion*.